

need no scholarly consultation because a basic historical truth corresponds to the poetic truth of the text to which the motion picture has strictly adhered. Some of that may be due to Shakespeare's use of Plutarch; but one is tempted to credit it also to some sort of divination, the power to interpret the historic event in its essentially human terms. The chance that these characters may look like ancient Romans depends on this rather than on the accuracy of single little items. And the drama in its quality and development will be found to correspond to actual Roman traits. I remember Mr. Mankiewicz remarking once that in directing the big speeches he had kept in mind the conventional motions and style of classic oratory. The coincidence of art and history was perfect there; for in ancient Rome oratory was cultivated as an art, and, like opera now, it had its fans. The dialogue with the crowd is part of the Roman feeling for "life as spectacle," then as now. And the most mournful spectacle, by the way, can be the most thrilling. Horace says that the noisiest affairs in Rome were the funerals. This confirms the main lesson that a technical adviser on a historical picture will, I think, draw from his experience; namely, that history ought to be consulted not in search of alibis but because its suggestions are likely to be more interesting, more usable, and more imaginative than anything we may dare invent in their place.

Shakespeare in One Reel

ROBERT HAMILTON BALL

ROBERT HAMILTON BALL is a professor of English and chairman of the Division of Language, Literature, and the Arts at Queens College of the City of New York. During the summer of 1949 he taught at the University of California, Los Angeles. Professor Ball has published several articles about motion picture productions of Shakespeare's plays in the *Pacific Spectator* and the *Shakespeare Quarterly*. As a Guggenheim Fellow, he began his book *Shakespeare on Film* upon which he is currently working.

VARIOUS JOURNALS—trade, specialized, and general—have in recent years carried considerable comment on Shakespeare films. Naturally enough, because of their current interest, the discussion has largely been confined to films recent or planned—Olivier's *Henry V* and *Hamlet*, Welles's *Macbeth* and *Othello*, MGM's *Julius Caesar*, and others pending. The Olivier pictures have been responsible for three books,¹ and Welles's *Othello* is the taking-off point for Micheál MacLiammóir's delightful diary, *Put Money in Thy Purse* (London: Methuen, 1952). One remembers, too, the volume occasioned by MGM's *Romeo and Juliet*² as far back as 1936. If the many brochures and articles, the publicity and the reviews are added, it is evident that there has grown up a substantial bibliography on the subject of films derived from Shakespeare's plays.

Nevertheless, very little has been written about the origins of this movement, now if not rampant, at least couchant; and it takes considerable digging to unearth the facts or assumptions which can be called reasonable. Shakespeare films have a history. I propose to say here something about the beginning of that history, limiting myself to the days when films were of a thousand feet or less and in one reel.

As far as I have been able to discover, the first Shakespeare film

¹ C. Clayton Hutton, *The Making of Henry V* (London: published by author, printed by E. J. Day & Co., Ltd., 1944); Brenda Cross, ed., *The Film Hamlet: A Record of Its Production* (London: Saturn Press, 1948); Alan Dent, ed., *Hamlet, the Film and the Play* (London: World Film Publications, Ltd., 1948).

² William Shakespeare, *Romeo and Juliet: A Motion Picture Edition*, a preliminary guide . . . prepared by Max J. Herzberg (New York: Random House, copyright 1936).